

Wilbur and Orville Wright: The First Airplane

Wilbur and Orville Wright are the American inventors who made a small engine-powered flying machine. They proved that flight without the aid of gas-filled balloons was possible.

Wilbur Wright was born in 1867 near Melville, Indiana. His brother Orville was born four years later in Dayton, Ohio.

As they grew up, the Wright brothers experimented with mechanical things. Later, the Wright brothers began to design their own flying machine. They used ideas they had developed from earlier experiments with a toy helicopter, kites, the printing machine and bicycles.

Soon, they needed a place to test their ideas about flight. The best place with the best wind conditions seemed to be a piece of sandy land in North Carolina along the coast of the Atlantic Ocean. It was called Kill Devil Hill, near the town of Kitty Hawk.

The Wright brothers did many tests with gliders at Kitty Hawk. With these tests, they learned how to solve many problems.

By the autumn of 1903, Wilbur and Orville had designed and built an airplane powered by a gasoline engine. The plane had wings 12 meters across. It weighed about 340 kilograms, including the pilot.

On December 17th, 1903, they made the world's first flight in a machine that was heavier than air and powered by an engine. Orville flew the plane 36 meters. He was in the air for 12 seconds. The two brothers made three more flights that day.

Four other men watched the Wright brothers' first flights. One of the men took pictures. Few newspapers, however, noted the event.

It was almost five years before the Wright brothers became famous. In 1908, Wilbur went to France. He gave demonstration flights at heights of 90 meters. A French company agreed to begin making the Wright brothers' flying machine.

Orville made successful flights in the United States at the time Wilbur was in France. The United States War Department agreed to buy a Wright brothers' plane. Wilbur and Orville suddenly became world heroes. But the brothers were not seeking fame. They returned to Dayton where they continued to improve their airplanes. They taught many others how to fly.

Wilbur Wright died of typhoid fever in 1912. Orville Wright continued designing and inventing until he died many years later, in 1948.

Today, the Wright brothers' first airplane is in the Air and Space Museum in Washington, D.C. Visitors to the museum can look at the Wright brothers' small plane. Then they can walk to another area and see space vehicles and a rock collected from the moon. The world has changed a lot since Wilbur and Orville Wright began the modern age of flight over one hundred years ago.

I'm John Russell.

Marilyn Rice Christiano wrote this story for VOA Learning English. John Russell adapted it.

Quiz - Wilbur and Orville Wright: The First Airplane

Vocabulary

glider - n. วัตถุที่บินได้คล้ายเครื่องบินแต่ไม่มีเครื่องยนต์

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What significant achievement are Wilbur and Orville Wright known for, according to the article?

- A. Inventing the first gas-filled balloon for flight.
- B. Proving that flight was possible without the aid of gas-filled balloons.
- C. Developing a type of printing machine.
- D. Designing the first successful toy helicopter.

2. According to the article, where was Orville Wright born?

- A. Near Melville, Indiana.
- B. In Dayton, Ohio.
- C. In North Carolina.
- D. In Washington, D.C.

3. What type of objects did the Wright brothers primarily experiment with as they grew up?

- A. Artistic sculptures.
- B. Agricultural machinery.
- C. Mechanical things.
- D. Chemical compounds.

4. Which of the following was NOT mentioned as an inspiration or source of ideas for the Wright brothers' flying machine design?

- A. A toy helicopter.

- B. Kites.
- C. Submarines.
- D. Bicycles.

5. Why did the Wright brothers choose Kill Devil Hill near Kitty Hawk, North Carolina, as their testing location?

- A. It was close to their hometown.
- B. It offered the best wind conditions.
- C. It was a secret, isolated military base.
- D. It had a large body of fresh water for landings.

6. What kind of unpowered flying objects did the Wright brothers use for many early tests at Kitty Hawk to solve problems?

- A. Hot air balloons.
- B. Helicopters.
- C. Gliders.
- D. Kites.

7. By what time did Wilbur and Orville Wright design and build their first gasoline engine-powered airplane?

- A. The summer of 1902.
- B. The autumn of 1903.
- C. The spring of 1904.
- D. The winter of 1905.

8. On December 17th, 1903, who was the pilot of the world's first engine-powered, heavier-than-air flight?

- A. Wilbur Wright.
- B. Orville Wright.
- C. John Russell.
- D. One of the four observers.

9. How long did the Wright brothers' very first successful flight on December 17th, 1903, last?

- A. 36 seconds.
- B. 12 minutes.
- C. 12 seconds.
- D. 340 seconds.

10. What was the immediate public and media response to the Wright brothers' first flights?

- A. It was widely celebrated by many newspapers.
- B. Four other men immediately became famous.
- C. It received little attention from newspapers.
- D. It caused a global sensation instantly.

11. Approximately how long did it take for the Wright brothers to become famous after their first flight?

- A. Less than a year.
- B. Exactly two years.
- C. Almost five years.
- D. Over ten years.

12. What was a significant outcome of Wilbur's demonstration flights in France and Orville's successful flights in the United States?

- A. They decided to retire from aviation.
- B. They became world heroes and the U.S. War Department bought a plane.
- C. They started a new printing business.
- D. They began designing rockets for space travel.

13. Despite their newfound fame, what did the Wright brothers prioritize after their international success?

- A. Seeking further public recognition and awards.
- B. Expanding their business into balloon manufacturing.
- C. Continuing to improve their airplanes and teach others to fly.
- D. Moving permanently to France to collaborate with the French company.

14. Which of the Wright brothers continued his work in design and invention for many years after the other's death?

- A. Wilbur Wright.
- B. Orville Wright.
- C. Both brothers equally.
- D. Neither brother continued their work.

15. Where is the Wright brothers' first airplane currently located?

- A. In a museum in Dayton, Ohio.

- B. At Kill Devil Hill, North Carolina.
- C. In the Air and Space Museum in Washington, D.C.
- D. At a private collection in France.